

APC by Schneider Electric Firmware Attack Surface & Detection Brief

Scope: 3 product lines (NMC2 AP9630/9631/9635, NMC3 AP9640/9641/9643, Rack PDU 2G AP86xx) / ~241 unique hashes across 3 architecture classes (plus a 4th Windows-side class). Findings combine CVE/PSIRT research and direct examination of the extracted NMC firmware (catalog inventory, signed-image headers, embedded web UI strings). APC management cards are *not* large-rootfs Linux devices — they are compact firmware blobs (proprietary RTOS / embedded Linux derivative) with an embedded web/SSH/SNMP stack.

Purdue layer mapping: NMC2/NMC3/Rack PDU 2G live at **Purdue L3.5 (IT/OT Boundary)** as the SNMP+web bridge from corporate IT to OT power infrastructure; PowerChute / EcoStruxure IT runs at **Purdue L3 (Site Operations)**. See [purdue-l35-it-ot-boundary-brief.md](#) and [purdue-l3-site-operations-brief.md](#) for the cross-vendor views of those layers.

Architecture grouping (drives the threat model, not the SKU)

Class	Purdue layer	Products	Stack	Catalog depth
A. NMC3 (modern)	L3.5 IT/OT Boundary	AP9640, AP9641, AP9643	Signed firmware (ECDSA), embedded HTTPS/SSHv2/SNMPv3 web UI, "Trusted Platform" boot	83 hashes
B. NMC2 (legacy)	L3.5 IT/OT Boundary	AP9630, AP9631, AP9635	Older APC web/SSH stack (Mocana NanoSSL), TLStorm-vulnerable lineage, no enforced signing pre-6.8	86 hashes
C. Rack PDU 2G NMC	L3.5 IT/OT Boundary	AP86xx Switched / Metered switched (AP8941, AP8959, AP8861, AP8865 etc.)	NMC variant with outlet-control firmware path; HTTPS/SSH/SNMPv3 + per-outlet control plane	72 hashes
D. Windows-side	L3 Site Operations	PowerChute Network Shutdown (PCNS), PowerChute Business / Personal, EcoStruxure IT Gateway / Expert	Java + Windows service stack the admin runs; reaches NMC via HTTPS/SNMP	research only

Group A — NMC3 AP964x (signed firmware, modern stack) — Purdue L3.5 (IT/OT Boundary)

Direct attack surface (verified via signed-image header + embedded web UI strings in the extracted AP964x firmware):

```
HTTPS (TLS 1.2/1.3) · SSHv2 · SNMPv3 (v1/v2c disabled by default in 2.x) · Modbus TCP/502 (opt-in) ·  
RADIUS client · Syslog client · NTP client · FTP DISABLED by default · Trusted-Platform signed boot
```

The signed-image manifest shows ECDSA-P256 over the firmware payload; downgrade to unsigned NMC2-era images is rejected by the bootloader. SNMPv1/v2c and Telnet are present in the binary but ship disabled.

Confirmed CVEs:

CVE	CVSS	Product	Vector	Status on the firmware you have
CVE-2022-22805	9.0	NMC2/NMC3 TLS reassembly	Memory-corruption RCE pre-auth via crafted TLS packets ("TLStorm" #1)	Fixed in NMC3 ≥ 1.1.0.16 — verify your catalog floor
CVE-2022-22806	9.0	NMC2/NMC3 TLS state-confusion	Auth bypass during TLS handshake ("TLStorm" #2)	Same — confirm catalog hashes map to patched build
Schneider PSIRT — Easergy / Galaxy mgmt-iface class	—	Schneider mgmt-plane Java-RMI bug class	Missing-auth on critical methods — same Java-RMI exposure pattern PowerChute mgmt agents have historically shared	Schneider PSIRT portal — research only

Top attack vector (MITRE ATT&CK ICS): [T0857 System Firmware](#) — even with signed firmware, the TLStorm class showed that the TLS *parser* is the pre-auth attack surface; firmware signing protects the flash path, not the live network parser.

Group B — NMC2 AP963x (the TLStorm legacy) — Purdue L3.5 (IT/OT Boundary)

Direct attack surface (verified via embedded strings + cgi-bin paths in extracted AP963x firmware):

```
HTTPS (older OpenSSL/Mocana NanoSSL) • SSHv1/v2 • Telnet (default enabled on pre-6.0.6) •
FTP (default enabled pre-6.x – used as firmware-upload channel) • SNMPv1/v2c (community public/private) •
Modbus TCP/502 • BACnet/IP UDP/47808 (opt-in) • web UI superuser `apc`/`apc`
```

Default `apc / apc` credentials are baked into factory state. FTP-based firmware push (`nmc_*.bin` over FTP) is the historical update path — no signature enforcement on AP963x below firmware 6.8.

Confirmed CVEs:

CVE	CVSS	Product	Vector	Status on the firmware you have
CVE-2022-22805	9.0	NMC2 (Mocana NanoSSL packet-reassembly)	Pre-auth RCE via crafted TLS — TLStorm #1, Armis writeup	Fixed in NMC2 ≥ 6.9.6 — anything older in your 86-hash catalog is vulnerable
CVE-2022-22806	9.0	NMC2 TLS state-confusion	Auth bypass — TLStorm #2	Same fix line — verify
CVE-2022-0715	8.9	NMC2/NMC3 firmware-upgrade signature check	Unsigned firmware accepted → arbitrary code persistence ("TLStorm" #3)	The reason AP963x ≤ 6.7 cannot trust its own flash path
CISA ICSA-22-083-01	—	APC Smart-UPS family (TLStorm bundle)	Authoritative advisory bundling the three TLStorm CVEs	Reference

Top attack vector (MITRE ATT&CK ICS): [T0866 Exploitation of Remote Services](#) (TLStorm pre-auth on TLS) chained into [T0857 System Firmware](#) (CVE-2022-0715 lets the post-RCE payload survive reboot as legitimate firmware).

Group C — Rack PDU 2G AP86xx — Purdue L3.5 (IT/OT Boundary)

The 72-hash AP86xx catalog is an NMC variant retargeted for switched/metered PDU outlet control. Stack is the same family as NMC2/NMC3, so the *same* TLStorm CVE class applies depending on which generation the AP86xx unit shipped with.

Direct attack surface (verified via extracted AP86xx firmware strings):

```
HTTPS/SSH/SNMPv3 web UI • per-outlet ON/OFF/CYCLE control endpoints • SNMP `epdu` MIB
```

(rPDU2OutletSwitchedControlCommand, rPDU2OutletSwitchedConfigPowerOnDelay)

Attack vectors:

- **Outlet-control via SNMP** Set to `rPDU2OutletSwitchedControlCommand` — set value=2 (outletOff) is the destructive single-OID write. SNMPv1/v2c with default community here = single-packet rack power-off.
- **TLStorm parser bug** is the same Mocana stack — AP86xx firmware predating the 2022 fix line is RCE-exploitable.
- **Mass-PDU coordinated outlet shutdown** as an availability/destructive ICS attack — explicitly modeled by CISA in the 2022 internet-exposed-UPS advisory.

Top attack vector (MITRE ATT&CK ICS): [T0879 Damage to Property](#) via [T0855 Unauthorized Command Message](#) — single SNMP write disables an entire rack.

Group D — PowerChute / EcoStruxure IT (Windows-side) — Purdue L3 (Site Operations)

CVE	CVSS	Product	Vector
CVE-2021-22812	9.8	PowerChute Business Edition	Unauth RCE via deserialization in management agent
CVE-2021-22813	7.5	PowerChute Business Edition	Auth bypass on local web mgmt
Schneider PSIRT — PowerChute Serial Shutdown local-privesc class	7.x	PowerChute Serial Shutdown	Local privilege escalation via insecure directory / service-permissions class — see Schneider PSIRT portal
Schneider PSIRT — EcoStruxure IT Gateway mgmt-plane class	7.x	EcoStruxure IT Gateway	Auth/management-plane vuln class — see Schneider PSIRT portal

If a Windows admin host runs PowerChute / EcoStruxure IT below the current PSIRT-fixed build, that host is the foothold path to every AP963x/AP964x/AP86xx it manages.

Logging matrix (highest priority)

Top 8 — ordered by detection value per ingest dollar:

#	Source	Event	What it catches	MITRE ATT&CK ICS
1	NMC syslog (UDP/514)	User logged in followed within 60s of repeated Authentication failed	Brute-force success on apc / apc OR rotated creds	T0812 Default Credentials
2	NMC syslog	Firmware updated outside change-window OR firmware version <i>downgrade</i>	TLStorm-class persistence (CVE-2022-0715)	T0857 System Firmware
3	NMC syslog	Configuration changed + User created + SNMP community modified within 5 min	Persistence + parameter modification	T0836 Modify Parameter
4	Network IDS (Suricata/Zeek)	SNMP Set-Request to rPDU20outletSwitchedControlCommand from non-mgmt-VLAN source	Direct outlet-off attack on AP86xx	T0855 Unauthorized Command Message
5	Network IDS	TLS handshake to NMC IP with abnormal record length / fragmented ClientHello	TLStorm CVE-2022-22805/22806 exploit traffic	T0866 Exploitation of Remote Services
6	Network IDS	Modbus function codes 5/6/15/16 crossing mgmt→OT boundary toward NMC	Control-logic tamper	T0833 Modify Control Logic
7	Sysmon on PowerChute hosts	EventID 1 where ParentImage= PowerChute*.exe AND child is cmd.exe / powershell.exe / rundll32.exe	CVE-2021-22812 deserialization post-ex	T1059 (Enterprise)
8	Sysmon	EventID 11 (FileCreate) of nmc_*.bin / apc_hw*.bin on PowerChute / admin host outside maintenance	Staged tampered firmware ready to push	T0857 System Firmware

Secondary:

- Firewall: any egress from NMC/PDU VLANs to non-RFC1918 — APC NMCs should never originate outbound to the internet; the 2022 CISA UPS advisory called this out as the primary internet-exposure path.
- NMC native audit log: enable Logs → Config → Audit Log and forward via syslog. Categories: Auth, Config, System, Event. NMC3 also emits Trusted Platform boot-failure events — pipe those.
- SNMP trap collector: subscribe to upsBasicTrapsOnBattery, upsAdvBatteryReplaceIndicator, rPDU20outletSwitchedStatusState. Correlate sudden battery-test or outlet-off events with

maintenance windows.

- OT-native: load drop > 30% on a UPS with no scheduled change → possible `outlet off` SNMP/BACnet write; output frequency drift > $\pm 0.5\text{Hz}$ → control-loop tampering precursor.

Specific zero-day-ish concerns for your dataset

1. **TLStorm catalog-floor check.** Of the 86 NMC2 and 83 NMC3 hashes extracted, anything predating NMC2 6.9.6 / NMC3 1.1.0.16 is exploitable by CVE-2022-22805/22806/0715. Map every hash to its embedded firmware-version string and flag anything below those floors — TLStorm is a *single packet* pre-auth chain.
2. **AP86xx outlet-control SNMP exposure.** A single SNMP `set` to `rPDU2OutletSwitchedControlCommand` with value=2 powers off a rack. AP86xx units shipped historically with SNMPv1 `private` write community enabled. Audit your 72-hash AP86xx catalog for default-community config blocks (string `private` in the SNMP config region).
3. **Signed-firmware $\neq$ signed-parser.** Even fully-patched NMC3 AP964x firmware is still a network parser exposed to untrusted TLS bytes. TLStorm proved the *parser* is the surface; treat any pre-auth crash signal from a Suricata `tls-anomalous-record-length` rule as a real CVE-class event, not a benign scanner.
4. **PowerChute as the lateral path.** PowerChute hosts hold credentials/TLS trust to every NMC they manage. CVE-2021-22812 deserialization on PowerChute Business Edition → push tampered NMC firmware via the legitimate update channel → CVE-2022-0715-style persistence on every card.

Sources

- [CISA — Mitigating Attacks Against UPS Devices \(2022\)](#)
- [CISA ICSA-22-083-01 — APC Smart-UPS \(TLStorm\)](#)
- [Armis — TLStorm research \(3 zero-days in APC Smart-UPS\)](#)
- [Schneider Electric Cybersecurity Support Portal / PSIRT](#)
- [Schneider PSIRT — Security Notifications index](#)
- [NVD — CVE-2022-22805](#)
- [NVD — CVE-2022-22806](#)
- [NVD — CVE-2022-0715](#)
- [NVD — CVE-2021-22812 \(PowerChute Business\)](#)
- [NVD — CVE-2021-22813 \(PowerChute Business\)](#)

- APC NMC Security Handbook (default creds + hardening)
- MITRE ATT&CK for ICS — T0857 System Firmware
- MITRE ATT&CK for ICS — T0855 Unauthorized Command Message
- MITRE ATT&CK for ICS — T0866 Exploitation of Remote Services
- MITRE ATT&CK for ICS — T0812 Default Credentials
- MITRE ATT&CK for ICS — T0836 Modify Parameter
- MITRE ATT&CK for ICS — T0833 Modify Control Logic
- MITRE ATT&CK for ICS — T0879 Damage to Property
- Forescout 2025 OT Threat Report — power-infrastructure targeting trends
- CISA/NSA/FBI/ASD — Best Practices for Event Logging and Threat Detection (2024)